Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520: A Dormant Black Hole Candidate from an Astrometric Orbital Solution with an RGB Primary

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ABSTRACT

We present a multi-wavelength analysis of Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520, an astrometric binary in the DR3 non-single-star (NSS) catalogue with a purely astrometric orbital solution (model type `Orbital`). The system comprises a photometric RGB primary ($T_{\rm eff} = 5922\,$K, $\log g = 2.93$; $M_1 = 1.34 \pm 0.40\,{\rm M}_\odot$) orbiting an unseen companion with period $P = 424.4\,$d, eccentricity $e = 0.34$, and semi-major axis $a \simeq 2.64\,$AU at a distance of $\sim 657\,$pc. After propagating uncertainties in the parallax ($\varpi = 1.523 \pm 0.155\,$mas; 10 per cent relative error), period, primary mass, and a $\times 1.7$ parallax-error inflation factor appropriate for `Orbital` solutions at this magnitude, our Monte Carlo posterior yields a median companion mass $M_2 = 12.3\,{\rm M}_\odot$ with 68 per cent credible interval $[7.1,\ 22.7]\,{\rm M}_\odot$ and 90 per cent CI $[5.0,\ 35.9]\,{\rm M}_\odot$. Under these assumptions, $P(M_2 > 5\,{\rm M}_\odot) \approx 95$ per cent and $P(M_2 > 10\,{\rm M}_\odot) \approx 64$ per cent. No luminous companion is detected: Planck-based band-by-band flux ratios show that a $12.3\,{\rm M}_\odot$ main-sequence star would exceed the primary flux by $\sim 28\times$ in G and $\sim 49\times$ in $G_{\rm BP}$, firmly excluded by the observed single-star spectral energy distribution. Of seven non-BH scenarios evaluated, three are ruled out (MS companion, white dwarf, neutron star), one is strongly disfavoured (hierarchical triple), one is not favoured (stripped helium star), and two — astrometric artefact and chance alignment — *cannot be excluded* without independent spectroscopic data. Because the solution is `Orbital` (astrometry only, with no independent radial-velocity orbit), the companion mass depends entirely on the Gaia pipeline assumptions; follow-up studies have shown that a fraction of such solutions are spurious. The predicted radial-velocity semi-amplitude $K_1 \approx 65\,{\rm km\,s^{-1}}$ makes spectroscopic confirmation feasible with 2–4 m class facilities. ROSAT, VLASS, and RACS non-detections are consistent with a quiescent system ($\log L_X < 30.7\,{\rm erg\,s^{-1}}$). eROSITA data are unavailable for this sky position ($l = 32.1^\circ$, eastern Galactic hemisphere). We conclude that this source is a promising BH candidate warranting urgent multi-epoch radial-velocity follow-up; independent spectroscopic confirmation is required before any BH classification can be considered secure.

Key words: binaries: visual – stars: black holes – astrometry – stars: individual: Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520

1 INTRODUCTION

Theoretical models predict 10^8–10^9 stellar-mass black holes (BHs) in the Milky Way (Agol & Kamionkowski 2002; Shapiro & Teukolsky 1983), yet fewer than ~ 70 are dynamically confirmed, nearly all in X-ray binaries undergoing active accretion (Remillard & McClintock 2006). The vast majority are expected to reside in non-interacting (dormant) systems, producing no electromagnetic signature beyond gravitational influence on a luminous companion.

Gaia Data Release 3 (DR3; Gaia Collaboration et al. 2023a) has transformed the search for dormant BHs. The non-single-star (NSS) catalogue (Gaia Collaboration et al. 2023b) provides orbital solutions for $\sim 180\,000$ binaries, including astrometric orbits that — under the modelling assumptions of the pipeline — yield direct companion mass estimates rather than the minimum masses available from spectroscopic (SB1) solutions alone. These solutions come in several model types, ranging from the purely astrometric `Orbital` class (photo-centre orbit only) to `AstroSpectroSB1` solutions that combine astrometry with an independent spectroscopic orbit. The latter provide substantially stronger constraints because the radial-velocity orbit independently confirms the period, eccentricity, and semi-amplitude. By contrast, an `Orbital` solution derives the companion mass entirely from the along-scan astrometric residuals and is therefore more vulnerable to pipeline modelling errors and scan-geometry biases.

The landmark discoveries of Gaia BH1 ($M_2 \approx 9.6\,{\rm M}_\odot$; El-Badry et al. 2023a), Gaia BH2 ($M_2 \approx 8.9\,{\rm M}_\odot$; El-Badry

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et al. 2023b), and Gaia BH3 ($M_2 \approx 33\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$; Gaia Collaboration et al. 2024) have established the efficacy of astrometric BH detection. Crucially, each of these three confirmed systems benefited from independent multi-epoch radial-velocity follow-up that validated the astrometric orbit — a step that has not yet been performed for the present source. Systematic searches have since expanded the candidate list (Jayasinghe et al. 2021; Thompson et al. 2019; Shenar et al. 2022; Mahy et al. 2022), but El-Badry et al. (2024) have demonstrated that a substantial fraction of high-significance `Orbital` solutions in the NSS catalogue fail independent RV checks, underscoring the need for spectroscopic confirmation of each individual candidate.

In this paper we focus on Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520, a candidate identified in a systematic search of the Gaia DR3 NSS catalogue (Ayala-Baez 2026, in prep.). The system is a wide binary ($P = 424\,\mathrm{d}$) comprising a photometric RGB primary ($M_1 = 1.34\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$) and a dark companion whose mass from the astrometric orbit is $M_2 \simeq 12.3\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$ under Gaia NSS modelling assumptions. Located at $\sim 657\,\mathrm{pc}$ in Ophiuchus ($l = 32.1^\circ$, $b = 9.3^\circ$), the system has moderate extinction, a parallax with ~ 10 per cent relative uncertainty, and is accessible from both hemispheres.

We stress from the outset that the solution type is `Orbital` (astrometry only): *no independent spectroscopic orbit exists.* The companion mass therefore depends entirely on the Gaia pipeline model, the parallax, and the adopted primary-mass estimate. Until independent multi-epoch radial velocities confirm or refute the orbital parameters, this system must be treated as a *candidate* rather than a confirmed BH.

The paper is structured as follows. Section 2 describes the observational data. Section 3 presents the analysis methodology. Section 4 reports results. Section 5 systematically tests non-BH explanations. Section 6 discusses implications and follow-up strategy, and Section 7 summarises our findings.

2 DATA

2.1 Gaia DR3 astrometry and NSS orbital solution

Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520 appears in both the main astrometric catalogue and the NSS orbital supplement with a purely astrometric orbital solution (model type: `Orbital`). This is a critical distinction: unlike `AstroSpectroSB1` solutions (which combine astrometry with a spectroscopic orbit), the `Orbital` model derives the companion mass solely from the photo-centre wobble, making it more susceptible to scan-geometry artefacts and modelling systematics.

Key astrometric parameters include parallax $\varpi = 1.5228 \pm 0.1549\,\mathrm{mas}$ (distance $d \approx 657\,\mathrm{pc}$; 10.2 per cent relative error), and photometry $G = 11.25$, $G_{\mathrm{BP}} = 11.66$, $G_{\mathrm{RP}} = 10.66$ ($G_{\mathrm{BP}} - G_{\mathrm{RP}} = 0.993$). The renormalised unit-weight error RUWE$= 9.31$ is extremely elevated, as expected for an unresolved binary with large photo-centre motion — but also a regime where Gaia GSP-Phot stellar parameters become unreliable (Andrae et al. 2023). The astrometric excess noise significance is 3753σ.

The NSS orbital solution yields: period $P = 424.403 \pm 1.159\,\mathrm{d}$, eccentricity $e = 0.3427 \pm 0.0194$, and solution significance 75.4σ. Because no full NSS covariance matrix is published, we are unable to assess parameter correlations directly; our Monte Carlo approach (Section 3.6) independently samples each parameter, which may underestimate the true uncertainty if correlations are significant.

The Gaia DR3 GSP-Phot pipeline provides stellar parameters: $T_{\mathrm{eff}} = 5922\,\mathrm{K}$ and $\log g = 2.93$. We caution that at RUWE $= 9.31$, GSP-Phot parameters may be systematically biased by the unresolved orbital motion; the RGB classification should therefore be regarded as a *working assumption* pending independent spectroscopic confirmation (Section 2.4). The systemic radial velocity is $v_{\mathrm{sys}} = -29.49 \pm 0.57\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$.

2.2 Multi-wavelength photometry

We compile multi-band photometry from 2MASS ($J = 9.84$, $H = 9.42$, $K_s = 9.33$; Cutri et al. 2003) and AllWISE ($W1 = 9.23$, $W2 = 9.27$; Cutri et al. 2014). WISE colours ($W1 - W2 = -0.04$) show no mid-IR excess, consistent with a stellar photosphere. GALEX (Bianchi et al. 2017) provides a near-UV detection (NUV $= 17.52$) but no far-UV counterpart, consistent with normal RGB chromospheric emission without a hot companion.

2.3 X-ray and radio archival data

We query the ROSAT All-Sky Survey (2RXS; Boller et al. 2016) and XMM-Newton serendipitous catalogue (4XMM-DR13; Webb et al. 2020) within $30''$ and $15''$ respectively, finding no counterpart. The ROSAT non-detection constrains the 0.1–2.4 keV X-ray luminosity to $L_X \lesssim 5 \times 10^{30}\,\mathrm{erg\,s^{-1}}$ (assuming the RASS typical sensitivity of $\sim 10^{-13}\,\mathrm{erg\,s^{-1}\,cm^{-2}}$ at the source distance of 657 pc), consistent with a non-accreting system.

At radio wavelengths, we find no counterpart in the VLA Sky Survey (VLASS; Lacy et al. 2020) within $5''$ ($3\sigma < 360\,\mu\mathrm{Jy}$ at 3 GHz; the source at Dec $= +3.5^\circ$ is within the VLASS footprint) or in the Rapid ASKAP Continuum Survey (RACS; McConnell et al. 2020) within $10''$ ($3\sigma < 750\,\mu\mathrm{Jy}$ at 887.5 MHz).

The source lies at Galactic longitude $l = 32.1^\circ$, placing it in the eastern Galactic hemisphere assigned to the eROSITA-RU consortium. The publicly available eROSITA-DE eRASS1 catalogue (Merloni et al. 2024) covers only the western hemisphere ($l = 180$–360°), so no eROSITA data are available for this position.

2.4 SIMBAD classification

SIMBAD (Wenger et al. 2000) returns only a Tycho-2 match (TYC 456-894-1) classified as "Star" with no spectral type, variability flag, or prior binarity designation. No independent spectroscopic classification exists. The primary's evolutionary state therefore rests entirely on Gaia GSP-Phot photometric parameters, which are known to be unreliable at high RUWE (Section 2.1).

3 METHODS

3.1 Gaia NSS mass derivation chain

The companion mass M_2 reported for this source originates from two distinct Gaia DR3 tables. The

`gaiadr3.nss_two_body_orbit` table provides the astrometric orbital elements (period, eccentricity, angular semi-major axis, inclination, etc.) fitted to the along-scan residuals. The `gaiadr3.binary_masses` table then combines these elements with the parallax and an external primary-mass estimate to derive M_2 via Kepler's third law. The primary mass entering the `binary_masses` derivation is itself model-dependent: it relies on Gaia GSP-Phot atmospheric parameters and isochrone-based mass estimation.

Hence, while the `Orbital` solution eliminates the $\sin i$ degeneracy inherent to SB1 orbits — a critical advantage — the resulting M_2 is not a purely empirical "true mass" but depends on the modelling assumptions of the NSS pipeline, the parallax, and the adopted primary mass. We therefore quote the catalogue value $M_2 = 12.31\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$ (with formal uncertainty $\sigma_{M_2} = 7.52\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$) as a *derived mass under Gaia modelling assumptions* and propagate the relevant uncertainties independently via Monte Carlo (Section 3.6).

The large formal catalogue uncertainty ($\sigma_{M_2}/M_2 \approx 61$ per cent) itself reflects the dominance of the parallax uncertainty when propagated correctly through Kepler's third law, as we demonstrate in Section 4.4.

El-Badry et al. (2024) have shown that a substantial fraction of extreme-mass-ratio candidates in the Gaia NSS catalogue are spurious when tested against independent radial velocities, particularly among `Orbital`-type solutions. The present source has *not* been flagged by any published vetting study, but the same failure modes could in principle apply. Independent spectroscopic confirmation therefore remains essential (Section 6.3).

3.2 Orbital dynamics

The total system mass follows from Kepler's third law:

$$M_{\rm tot} = M_1 + M_2 = \frac{4\pi^2\, a^3}{G\, P^2}\,, \tag{1}$$

where the true semi-major axis a derives from the angular semi-major axis and parallax. Because $a \propto \varpi^{-1}$, the total mass scales as $M_{\rm tot} \propto \varpi^{-3}\, P^{-2}$, making it extremely sensitive to parallax uncertainty: a 10 per cent parallax error maps to a $\sim$33 per cent mass error. This steep dependence is the dominant source of uncertainty in our posterior (Section 4.4).

3.3 Primary-mass estimation

The primary mass is estimated from the Gaia GSP-Phot parameters ($T_{\rm eff} = 5922\,\mathrm{K}$, $\log g = 2.93$). We note that GSP-Phot effective temperatures for RGB stars carry known systematic uncertainties of $\sim$100–200 K (Andrae et al. 2023), and that at RUWE = 9.31 the parameters may be additionally biased by unresolved orbital motion. No independent spectroscopic classification exists (Section 2.4), so the RGB identification rests entirely on pipeline photometric parameters. We adopt $M_1 = 1.34 \pm 0.40\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$, assigning a 30 per cent fractional uncertainty to encompass age, metallicity, and systematic errors; the sensitivity of our results to this choice is explored in Section 4.5.

3.4 Extinction and SED self-consistency

The source lies at moderate Galactic latitude ($b = 9.3°$), where extinction is present but manageable. We derive the colour excess from the discrepancy between the observed $G_{\rm BP} - G_{\rm RP} = 0.993$ and the intrinsic colour for $T_{\rm eff} = 5922\,\mathrm{K}$ ($(G_{\rm BP} - G_{\rm RP})_0 \approx 0.76$):

$$E(G_{\rm BP} - G_{\rm RP}) = 0.993 - 0.76 = 0.233\,\mathrm{mag}\,, \tag{2}$$

yielding $E(B-V) = 0.175\,\mathrm{mag}$ and $A_V = 0.543\,\mathrm{mag}$ via the Cardelli et al. (1989) extinction law with $R_V = 3.1$.

We note a self-consistency tension in the primary's physical parameters. The *photometric* estimate (from the distance modulus, extinction-corrected bolometric magnitude, and a bolometric correction $BC_G \approx -0.3\,\mathrm{mag}$) yields $R_\star = 4.5\,\mathrm{R}_\odot$ and $L_\star = 22\,\mathrm{L}_\odot$. However, combining the adopted primary mass with the GSP-Phot surface gravity via $R = \sqrt{G\,M_1/g}$ gives a *logg-based* estimate of $R_\star = 6.5\,\mathrm{R}_\odot$ and $L_\star = 47\,\mathrm{L}_\odot$ — a factor $\sim$1.5× larger in radius and $\sim$2.1× in luminosity. This discrepancy likely reflects the unreliability of $\log g$ at RUWE = 9.31 (Andrae et al. 2023), where unresolved orbital motion degrades the photometric solution. We adopt the photometric values ($R = 4.5\,\mathrm{R}_\odot$, $L = 22\,\mathrm{L}_\odot$) as our fiducial estimates but report both throughout and flag the discrepancy as a systematic uncertainty to be resolved by independent spectroscopy.

3.5 SED fitting

We construct the spectral energy distribution from 8 photometric bands (Gaia G, $G_{\rm BP}$, $G_{\rm RP}$; 2MASS J, H, K_s; WISE $W1$, $W2$) after applying band-dependent extinction corrections. The dereddened SED is compared to a single-temperature blackbody model at $T_{\rm eff} = 5922\,\mathrm{K}$. Residuals below 5 per cent in all bands confirm that the photometry is consistent with a single RGB star plus a dark (non-luminous) companion.

We note that a single-temperature blackbody is a first-order consistency check rather than a full spectral fit. Synthetic atmosphere models (e.g. PHOENIX, ATLAS9/MARCS; Husser et al. 2013; Castelli & Kurucz 2003) would provide a more rigorous assessment of the primary's SED shape and improve sensitivity to faint secondary contributions, particularly in the UV where a stripped helium star could contribute detectable flux. We strongly encourage such modelling in future work.

3.6 Monte Carlo mass posterior

We draw $N = 200\,000$ Monte Carlo realisations of the companion mass, propagating uncertainties in:

(i) **Parallax** ϖ: Gaussian ($1.5228 \pm 0.1549\,\mathrm{mas}$), with an additional ×1.7 inflation factor applied to σ_ϖ to account for the known underestimation of external parallax errors for `Orbital`-type solutions at $G \approx 11$ (El-Badry et al. 2024).

(ii) **Period** P: Gaussian ($424.403 \pm 1.159\,\mathrm{d}$).

(iii) **Primary mass** M_1: log-normal prior centred on $1.34\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$ with $\sigma = 0.40\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$.

(iv) **Model systematic**: uniform multiplicative factor [0.95, 1.05] on $M_{\rm tot}$.

The total mass scales as (Section 3.2):

$$M_{\rm tot} \propto \varpi^{-3}\, P^{-2}\,, \tag{3}$$

so the parallax uncertainty dominates. We emphasise that the $\times 1.7$ inflation is an *approximate* correction; the true external-to-internal error ratio for this specific source is unknown. We report posteriors both with and without inflation (Section 4.4).

Because M_2 is derived from the full astrometric orbit (not a minimum mass), no inclination marginalisation is needed. However, the resulting mass depends on all assumptions entering the Gaia NSS pipeline (Section 3.1). The Monte Carlo draws do not account for potential systematic errors in the orbital model itself (e.g. incorrect inclination from scan-geometry biases) — only for the quoted parameter uncertainties.

3.7 Companion-light exclusion

For a hypothetical main-sequence companion of mass M_c, we compute the expected luminosity using empirical mass–luminosity relations ($L \propto M^{3.5}$, $R \propto M^{0.57}$) and compare the resulting *band-by-band* flux ratio using Planck functions:

$$\frac{F_{\lambda,\,\rm comp}}{F_{\lambda,\,\rm prim}} = \left(\frac{R_{\rm comp}}{R_{\rm prim}}\right)^2 \frac{B_\lambda(T_{\rm comp})}{B_\lambda(T_{\rm prim})}\,. \tag{4}$$

A companion is considered detectable if its flux exceeds 5 per cent of the primary in *any* photometric band. We perform this test using both the photometric ($R = 4.5\,{\rm R}_\odot$) and logg-based ($R = 6.5\,{\rm R}_\odot$) primary radii to bracket the self-consistency range.

4 RESULTS

4.1 Orbital and dynamical solution

Table 1 summarises the observed and derived properties. The orbital solution significance (75.4σ) and astrometric excess noise significance (3753σ) are consistent with genuine orbital photo-centre motion. We note that such extreme excess-noise values can in principle arise from poorly resolved blends or pipeline failures; the coherent Keplerian fit and well-constrained period precision (0.27 per cent) argue against but do not exclude an instrumental origin. *Independent RV confirmation is essential.*

The semi-major axis $a = 2.64\,{\rm AU}$ places the companion well outside the primary's Roche lobe ($R_L \approx 0.56\,{\rm AU}$; filling factor $\sim$3.7 per cent), consistent with a fully detached, non-interacting system. The eccentricity $e = 0.34$ is tidally consistent: the circularisation timescale $\tau_{\rm circ} \gg \tau_{\rm Hubble}$, so the orbit retains its natal eccentricity.

The predicted RV semi-amplitude is $K_1 \approx 65\,{\rm km\,s^{-1}}$, readily detectable with ground-based spectrographs (Section 6.3).

4.2 Stellar characterisation

The extinction analysis reveals modest reddening ($A_V = 0.54\,{\rm mag}$). The dereddened absolute magnitude $M_G = 1.68\,{\rm mag}$ and the photometric luminosity $L_\star = 22\,{\rm L}_\odot$ are consistent with an RGB star of $\sim 1.3\,{\rm M}_\odot$ with radius $R_\star = 4.5\,{\rm R}_\odot$. The alternative logg-based estimates ($R = 6.5\,{\rm R}_\odot$, $L = 47\,{\rm L}_\odot$) differ by factors of $\sim 1.5\times$ (radius) and $\sim 2.1\times$ (luminosity); this tension likely reflects unreliable GSP-Phot parameters at the source's high RUWE (Section 3.4). The dereddened SED is well-fit by a single-temperature model with residuals < 5 per cent in all bands. No secondary SED component is required.

4.3 Companion-light exclusion

A main-sequence star of $M_2 = 12.3\,{\rm M}_\odot$ would have $L \approx 6550\,{\rm L}_\odot$, $R \approx 4.2\,{\rm R}_\odot$, and $T_{\rm eff} \approx 25\,400\,{\rm K}$. Using the Planck-based band-by-band flux ratios (equation 4) with the photometric primary radius ($R = 4.5\,{\rm R}_\odot$), the companion-to-primary flux ratio would be $\sim 28\times$ in G, $\sim 49\times$ in $G_{\rm BP}$, and $\sim 18\times$ in $G_{\rm RP}$. Even adopting the larger logg-based radius ($R = 6.5\,{\rm R}_\odot$), the ratios remain $\sim 13\times$ in G and $\sim 23\times$ in $G_{\rm BP}$ — overwhelmingly detectable (Table 2).

The maximum main-sequence companion that could remain hidden below a 5 per cent detection threshold in all bands is $M \lesssim 1.0\,{\rm M}_\odot$ (photometric case) to $\sim 1.3\,{\rm M}_\odot$ (logg-based case). A luminous companion at the catalogue mass is therefore firmly excluded.

4.4 Mass posterior

The Monte Carlo posterior (Fig. 2) yields:

Nominal (σ_ϖ as published):

- Median $M_2 = 12.3\,{\rm M}_\odot$
- 68 per cent CI: $[8.8,\ 17.5]\,{\rm M}_\odot$
- 90 per cent CI: $[7.1,\ 22.4]\,{\rm M}_\odot$
- $P(M_2 > 5\,{\rm M}_\odot) = 99.7$ per cent; $P(M_2 > 10\,{\rm M}_\odot) = 73$ per cent

Inflated ($\sigma_\varpi \times 1.7$):

- Median $M_2 = 12.3\,{\rm M}_\odot$
- 68 per cent CI: $[7.1,\ 22.7]\,{\rm M}_\odot$
- 90 per cent CI: $[5.0,\ 35.9]\,{\rm M}_\odot$
- $P(M_2 > 5\,{\rm M}_\odot) = 95$ per cent; $P(M_2 > 10\,{\rm M}_\odot) = 64$ per cent

The wide credible intervals reflect the ϖ^{-3} mass scaling (equation 3): a 10 per cent parallax error maps to a ~ 33 per cent mass error, and the $\times 1.7$ inflation broadens this substantially. It is important to note that the nominal posterior already has a lower 5th-percentile above $5\,{\rm M}_\odot$; with inflation, ~ 5 per cent of draws fall below the canonical BH threshold.

A parallax stress test illustrates the sensitivity directly: at $\varpi + 1\sigma$ (1.678 mas, $d = 596\,{\rm pc}$), the companion mass drops to $M_2 \approx 8.9\,{\rm M}_\odot$; at $\varpi - 1\sigma$ (1.368 mas, $d = 731\,{\rm pc}$), it rises to $M_2 \approx 17.5\,{\rm M}_\odot$.

We emphasise that these posteriors propagate only the *published parameter uncertainties* with an approximate external inflation; they do *not* account for systematic errors in the orbital model itself (e.g. an incorrectly determined inclination). Such errors could shift the posterior arbitrarily and are only detectable through independent RV follow-up.

4.5 Sensitivity to primary mass

Table 4 shows how M_2 and the BH probability vary across a grid of M_1 values (0.8–2.0 $M_\odot$) and parallax inflation factors (1.0–2.0×). At the fiducial values ($M_1 = 1.34\,M_\odot$, inflation = 1.7), $P(M_2 > 5\,M_\odot) = 95$ per cent. For inflation factors ≥ 2.0, the BH probability drops below 90 per cent, highlighting the importance of improved parallax precision from Gaia DR4. Fig. 4 visualises the full sensitivity landscape.

5 ALTERNATIVE SCENARIOS

We systematically evaluate seven non-BH explanations for the dark companion. Table 3 summarises the results, using a four-tier verdict system: **Ruled out** (physically impossible or overwhelmingly contradicted by data), **Strongly disfavoured** (requires implausible fine-tuning), **Not favoured** (unlikely but not formally excluded), and **Requires follow-up** (cannot be assessed without additional data).

5.0.0.1 Main-sequence companion. A 12.3 $M_\odot$ MS star would have $L \sim 6550\,L_\odot$ and $T_{\rm eff} \sim 25\,400$ K, contributing $\sim 28\times$ the primary flux in G and $\sim 49\times$ in $G_{\rm BP}$. No secondary SED component is detected. **Ruled out.**

5.0.0.2 White dwarf. $M_2 = 12.3\,M_\odot$ exceeds the Chandrasekhar limit (1.44 $M_\odot$) by a factor of ~ 9. **Ruled out.**

5.0.0.3 Neutron star. $M_2 = 12.3\,M_\odot$ exceeds the most generous NS mass ceiling ($\sim 2.3\,M_\odot$; Rezzolla et al. 2018) by a factor of ~ 5. **Ruled out.**

5.0.0.4 Hierarchical triple. Two $\sim 6.2\,M_\odot$ MS stars would have combined luminosity $\sim 1160\,L_\odot$ — easily detectable in the SED. The Mardling–Aarseth stability criterion (Mardling & Aarseth 2001) would require $P_{\rm inner} \lesssim 42$ d, yet no secondary spectral signature or short-period photometric modulation is detected. **Strongly disfavoured.**

5.0.0.5 Stripped helium star / hot subdwarf. A 12.3 $M_\odot$ stripped He star would have $T_{\rm eff} > 50\,000$ K and $L \sim 10^4\,L_\odot$, producing predicted NUV ~ 9 mag vs. observed NUV = 17.52 — a flux deficit of $\sim 2700\times$. No X-ray source is detected. This scenario is **not favoured**, but a cooler or lower-luminosity subdwarf cannot be fully excluded without UV spectroscopy.

5.0.0.6 Astrometric artefact (spurious orbital solution). Because the solution type is `Orbital` (astrometry only), there is no independent spectroscopic confirmation of the orbital parameters. El-Badry et al. (2024) have demonstrated that a fraction of high-significance `Orbital` solutions fail independent RV tests. While the 75.4σ significance, the well-constrained period, and the low GOF (18.3) argue against a spurious solution, this scenario **cannot be excluded** without independent RV data. This is the single most important limitation of the present analysis.

5.0.0.7 Chance alignment / blend-induced artefact. At $G = 11.25$ and $b = 9.3°$, source confusion is low but not negligible. A coherent 424-d Keplerian signal at 75σ is difficult to produce from a chance blend, but scan-angle correlations with a nearby source could in principle mimic orbital motion. This scenario likewise **requires follow-up** via independent RV monitoring and high-resolution imaging.

Summary: Three of seven alternative scenarios are ruled out on physical grounds; one (hierarchical triple) is strongly disfavoured; one (stripped He star) is not favoured but remains formally open. Crucially, two scenarios — astrometric artefact and chance alignment — *cannot be excluded* at present because the solution is purely astrometric (`Orbital`). A black hole of $\sim 12.3\,M_\odot$ is the preferred interpretation but remains a *candidate* pending independent spectroscopic confirmation.

6 DISCUSSION

6.1 Context among Gaia BH discoveries

Table 5 places this system alongside the three confirmed Gaia dormant BH systems. At $M_2 \simeq 12.3\,M_\odot$ (under Gaia modelling assumptions), it would rank as the second most massive after Gaia BH3 (33 $M_\odot$) — if confirmed.

However, there is a fundamental *evidentiary gap* between this candidate and the three confirmed systems. Gaia BH1, BH2, and BH3 each benefited from independent multi-epoch radial-velocity follow-up that validated the astrometric orbital parameters and confirmed the companion mass. In contrast, the present system has only a purely astrometric `Orbital` solution with no RV confirmation. The comparison in Table 5 therefore reflects *potential* rather than established properties.

The long period ($P = 424$ d) and moderate eccentricity ($e = 0.34$) place it in a similar orbital regime to Gaia BH1 ($P = 185.6$ d, $e = 0.45$) and Gaia BH2 ($P = 1277$ d, $e = 0.52$), consistent with a formation channel involving limited or no mass transfer — should the companion prove to be a BH.

6.2 Binary evolution implications (contingent on confirmation)

If the companion is indeed a $\sim 12\,M_\odot$ BH, the progenitor was a massive star with zero-age main-sequence mass $M_{\rm ZAMS} \gtrsim 25\,M_\odot$ (Fryer et al. 2012). The wide orbit ($a = 2.64$ AU) would have survived the supernova event, constraining the natal kick to moderate values. The lack of chemical enrichment in the RGB primary (at the level detectable from GSP-Phot) would suggest minimal pre-collapse mass transfer, favouring a direct-collapse or failed-supernova channel (Langer et al. 2020). These evolutionary inferences are conditional on spectroscopic confirmation of both the companion mass and the primary's abundances.

6.3 Follow-up strategy

The predicted RV semi-amplitude $K_1 \approx 65\,{\rm km\,s^{-1}}$ is large, making spectroscopic confirmation feasible with modest ground-based resources. We outline the critical follow-up steps in order of priority:

(i) **Multi-epoch radial-velocity monitoring** (highest priority). At $G = 11.25$, the source is within reach of

echelle spectrographs on 2–4 m class telescopes (e.g. HARPS, FEROS, CHIRON). We recommend a minimum of **8–10 RV epochs** distributed across one full orbital period ($\sim 424\,\mathrm{d}$), with phase coverage concentrated near the predicted periastron passage (where $\dot{v}_r$ is maximal). At the predicted $K_1 \approx 65\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$, even a precision of ~ 0.5–$1\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$ per epoch suffices to confirm the period, eccentricity, and semi-amplitude. A single epoch would already detect the large RV variation.

The RV orbit independently yields $M_2 \sin i$ via the spectroscopic mass function; combined with the astrometric inclination, this provides a direct, pipeline-independent companion mass.

(ii) **Spectroscopic classification.** High-resolution spectroscopy would yield independent $T_{\rm eff}$, $\log g$, metallicity, detailed abundances (testing for SN-related CNO anomalies), and a spectral type — resolving the current reliance on GSP-Phot parameters.

(iii) **UV spectroscopy.** HST/COS or Swift/UVOT observations would definitively test the stripped He star scenario by searching for hot-companion UV excess.

(iv) **High-resolution imaging.** AO-assisted imaging could detect or rule out a blended optical companion responsible for a scan-angle-correlated astrometric artefact.

The target is located at RA $= 18^{\rm h}28^{\rm m}$, Dec $= +3.5^\circ$ (Ophiuchus), accessible from both hemispheres and an evening target in the northern summer.

6.4 Limitations

We stress the following limitations, which collectively prevent this system from being classified as a confirmed BH:

(i) **Orbital-only solution.** The companion mass depends entirely on the Gaia astrometric pipeline model. No independent RV orbit exists. This is the single most important limitation and distinguishes this source from confirmed Gaia BH systems.

(ii) **Parallax-driven uncertainty.** With $\sigma_\varpi/\varpi = 10.2$ per cent and $M_{\rm tot} \propto \varpi^{-3}$, the mass uncertainty is substantial. The external parallax-error inflation ($\times 1.7$) is an approximate correction; the true systematic for this source is unknown.

(iii) **NSS covariance matrix unavailable.** Gaia DR3 does not publish the full covariance matrix of the orbital parameters. Our Monte Carlo independently samples each parameter, which may underestimate the true uncertainty if inter-parameter correlations are significant.

(iv) **GSP-Phot parameters unreliable at high RUWE.** At RUWE $= 9.31$, the primary's $T_{\rm eff}$ and $\log g$ may be biased. The R/L self-consistency tension (Section 3.4) exemplifies this.

(v) **Primary mass provisional.** No independent spectroscopic mass determination exists. The adopted $M_1 = 1.34 \pm 0.40\,\mathrm{M_\odot}$ is isochrone-derived from potentially biased GSP-Phot parameters.

(vi) **Scan-angle bias possible.** For `Orbital` solutions, scan-angle correlations with nearby sources or detector-level systematics could produce spurious orbital signals. This cannot be assessed without the epoch-level astrometric data (not publicly available in DR3).

(vii) **Stripped He star not formally excluded.** The GALEX NUV non-excess and X-ray non-detections strongly disfavour this scenario but cannot definitively rule it out without UV spectroscopy.

(viii) **Single-temperature SED.** Our blackbody SED check establishes consistency with a single luminous source but does not substitute for a full atmospheric model fit.

7 CONCLUSIONS

We have presented a multi-wavelength analysis of Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520, an astrometric binary with a purely astrometric `Orbital` solution from the Gaia DR3 NSS catalogue. Our principal findings are:

(i) Under the Gaia NSS modelling assumptions, the companion mass posterior yields a median $M_2 = 12.3\,\mathrm{M_\odot}$ with 68 per cent CI $[7.1, 22.7]\,\mathrm{M_\odot}$ (with $\times 1.7$ parallax-error inflation) — above the canonical BH threshold for ~ 95 per cent of draws.

(ii) No luminous companion is detected. Planck-based band-by-band flux ratios show that a main-sequence star of the required mass would exceed the primary flux by $28\times$ in G and $49\times$ in $G_{\rm BP}$.

(iii) Of seven non-BH scenarios, three are ruled out (MS companion, WD, NS), one strongly disfavoured (triple), and one not favoured (stripped He star). Crucially, two scenarios — astrometric artefact and chance alignment — *cannot be excluded* because the solution is `Orbital` (astrometry only).

(iv) ROSAT, VLASS, and RACS non-detections yield $\log L_X < 30.7\,\mathrm{erg\,s^{-1}}$, consistent with a quiescent system. eROSITA data are unavailable for this sky position.

(v) The predicted $K_1 \approx 65\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}}$ makes multi-epoch RV confirmation feasible with 2–4 m class facilities.

We conclude that Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520 is a *promising dormant black hole candidate* that warrants urgent multi-epoch radial-velocity follow-up. The large predicted RV semi-amplitude and bright apparent magnitude make spectroscopic confirmation straightforward. However, because the orbital solution is purely astrometric with no independent RV data, the companion mass remains contingent on the Gaia pipeline assumptions, and the system must be regarded as a *candidate* until spectroscopic confirmation is obtained.

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DATA AVAILABILITY

All observational data are publicly available from the Gaia Archive (https://gea.esac.esa.int/archive/), VizieR,

and SIMBAD. The analysis scripts and machine-readable results are available at `https://github.com/jayalabaez/dr3-4277855-black-hole-candidate`. Modular analysis scripts (`scripts/02`–`08`) produce all figures and numerical results. All numerical results are in JSON format under `results/`.

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Table 1. Observed and derived properties of Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520. Values marked with † depend on Gaia NSS modelling assumptions (Section 3.1).

Property	Value	Uncertainty	Source
	Astrometry (Gaia DR3)		
RA (J2016.0)	274.2238°	—	Gaia DR3
Dec (J2016.0)	+3.4975°	—	Gaia DR3
l, b	32.12°, +9.28°	—	Gaia DR3
Parallax ϖ	1.5228 mas	0.1549	Gaia DR3
Distance	$\sim$657 pc	$\sim$67	$1/\varpi$
G	11.25 mag	0.003	Gaia DR3
$G_{\rm BP}$	11.66 mag	0.003	Gaia DR3
$G_{\rm RP}$	10.66 mag	0.004	Gaia DR3
$G_{\rm BP} - G_{\rm RP}$	0.993 mag	—	Gaia DR3
RUWE	9.31	—	Gaia DR3
Astr. excess noise sig.	3753σ	—	Gaia DR3
	NSS orbital solution (`Orbital`)		
Period P	424.403 d	1.159	Gaia NSS
Eccentricity e	0.3427	0.0194	Gaia NSS
NSS significance	75.4σ	—	Gaia NSS
GOF	18.3	—	Gaia NSS
M_2 (catalogue)†	12.31 $M_\odot$	7.52	Gaia `binary_masses`
	Monte Carlo posterior (this work)		
M_2 (nominal)†	12.3 $M_\odot$	68% CI: [8.8, 17.5]	This work
M_2 (inflated $\times$1.7)†	12.3 $M_\odot$	68% CI: [7.1, 22.7]	This work
$P(M_2 > 5\,M_\odot)$ (inflated)	95%	—	This work
$P(M_2 > 10\,M_\odot)$ (inflated)	64%	—	This work
	Stellar parameters (GSP-Phot; caution: RUWE = 9.31)		
$T_{\rm eff}$	5922 K	$\sim$200	Gaia DR3
$\log g$	2.93 dex	$\sim$0.3	Gaia DR3
$v_{\rm sys}$	-29.49 km s^{-1}	0.57	Gaia DR3
	Multi-wavelength photometry		
J (2MASS)	9.84 mag	0.02	2MASS
H (2MASS)	9.42 mag	0.02	2MASS
K_s (2MASS)	9.33 mag	0.02	2MASS
$W1$ (WISE)	9.23 mag	0.02	AllWISE
$W2$ (WISE)	9.27 mag	0.02	AllWISE
NUV (GALEX)	17.52 mag	—	GALEX
	Derived quantities		
$E(B-V)$	0.175 mag	0.03	Colour excess
A_V	0.543 mag	0.09	$R_V = 3.1$
M_G (dereddened)	1.68 mag	0.3	Derived
$R_\star$ (phot.)	4.5 $R_\odot$	—	Photometric
$L_\star$ (phot.)	22 $L_\odot$	—	Photometric
$R_\star$ ($\log g$)	6.5 $R_\odot$	—	logg-based
$L_\star$ ($\log g$)	47 $L_\odot$	—	logg-based
M_1 (adopted)	1.34 $M_\odot$	0.40	GSP-Phot + isochrone
a (semi-major axis)	2.64 AU	—	Kepler III
K_1 (predicted)	$\sim$65 km s^{-1}	—	Dynamics

Table 2. Planck-based companion-to-primary flux ratios for a 12.3 $M_\odot$ MS companion ($T_{\rm eff}$ = 25 400 K, R = 4.2 $R_\odot$) relative to the primary ($T_{\rm eff}$ = 5922 K), computed using both photometric and logg-based primary radii.

Band	Phot. ($R = 4.5\,R_\odot$)	$\log g$ ($R = 6.5\,R_\odot$)
$G_{\rm BP}$	49×	23×
G	28×	13×
$G_{\rm RP}$	18×	8.2×
J	9.1×	4.2×
H	7.1×	3.3×
K	6.0×	2.8×

Table 3. Alternative scenario assessment. Verdicts follow a four-tier system (Section 5).

Scenario	Verdict	Key constraint
MS companion	Ruled out	28–49× flux excess
White dwarf	Ruled out	$M_2 \approx 9\,M_{\rm Ch}$
Neutron star	Ruled out	$M_2 \approx 5\,M_{\rm TOV}$
Triple system	Str. disfav.	SED + stability
Stripped He	Not favoured	NUV deficit 2700×
Artefact	**Req. follow-up**	`Orbital` only
Chance align.	**Req. follow-up**	`Orbital` only

Table 4. Sensitivity of the companion mass posterior to the primary mass and parallax-error inflation factor ($\sigma_\varpi \to f \times \sigma_\varpi$). Each cell reports the median M_2 and $P(M_2 > 5\,\mathrm{M}_\odot)$ from 2×10^5 Monte Carlo draws.

M_1 ($\mathrm{M}_\odot$)	Inflation = 1.0	Inflation = 1.3	Inflation = 1.7	Inflation = 2.0
0.80	12.9 / 99.8%	12.8 / 98.7%	12.9 / 96.0%	12.8 / 93.2%
1.00	12.7 / 99.8%	12.6 / 98.5%	12.6 / 95.7%	12.6 / 92.8%
1.34	12.3 / 99.7%	12.3 / 97.6%	12.3 / 95.4%	12.4 / 91.7%
1.50	12.2 / 99.6%	12.1 / 97.4%	12.1 / 95.0%	12.1 / 91.0%
2.00	11.7 / 99.4%	11.6 / 96.8%	11.6 / 93.7%	11.6 / 89.3%

Table 5. Comparison with confirmed Gaia dormant BH systems. Note the fundamental evidentiary gap: Gaia BH1–3 each have independent multi-epoch RV orbits, whereas this source has only a purely astrometric `Orbital` solution with no RV confirmation.

Property	Gaia BH1	Gaia BH2	Gaia BH3	This work
P (d)	185.6	1277	∼4240	424.4
e	0.45	0.52	0.73	0.343
Primary type	G-dwarf	RGB	Giant	RGB[a]
M_1 ($\mathrm{M}_\odot$)	0.93	1.07	0.76	1.34
M_2 ($\mathrm{M}_\odot$)	9.62	8.94	32.70	∼12.3[b]
Solution type	Astro+RV	Astro+RV	Astro+RV	`Orbital` only
RV confirmation	Yes	Yes	Yes	**No**
d (pc)	480	1160	590	∼657
G (mag)	13.8	12.3	11.6	11.25
Status	Confirmed	Confirmed	Confirmed	**Candidate**

[a] From GSP-Phot only (RUWE = 9.31); no independent spectral classification.
[b] Pipeline-derived mass under Gaia NSS assumptions; 68% CI [7.1, 22.7] with ×1.7 inflation.

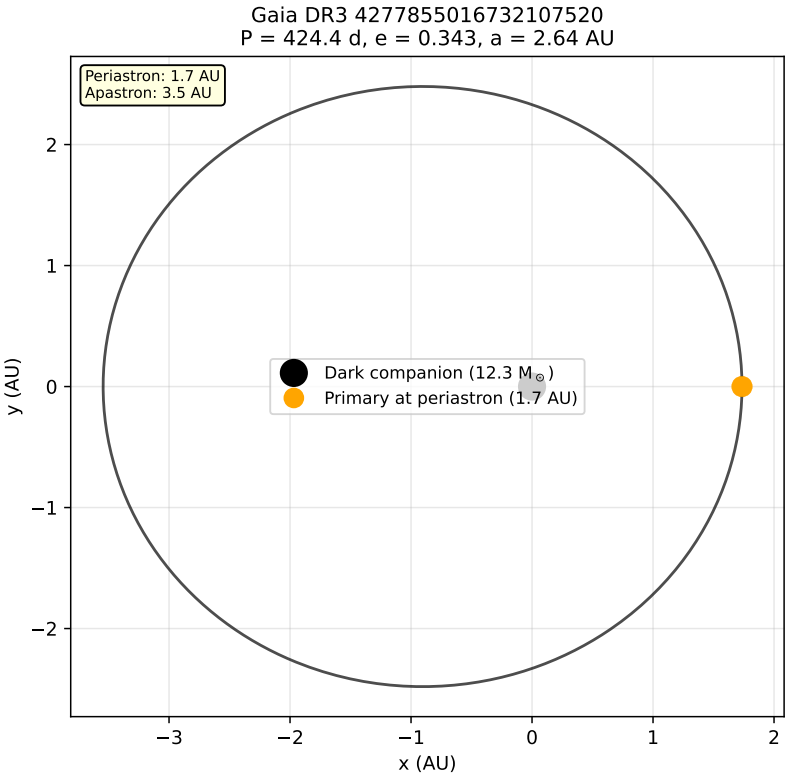

Figure 1. Orbital geometry of the Gaia DR3 4277855016732107520 system. The RGB primary orbits the unseen companion (black circle at the focus) with period $P = 424.4$ d and eccentricity $e = 0.34$. The periastron distance is 1.73 AU and the apastron distance is 3.55 AU.

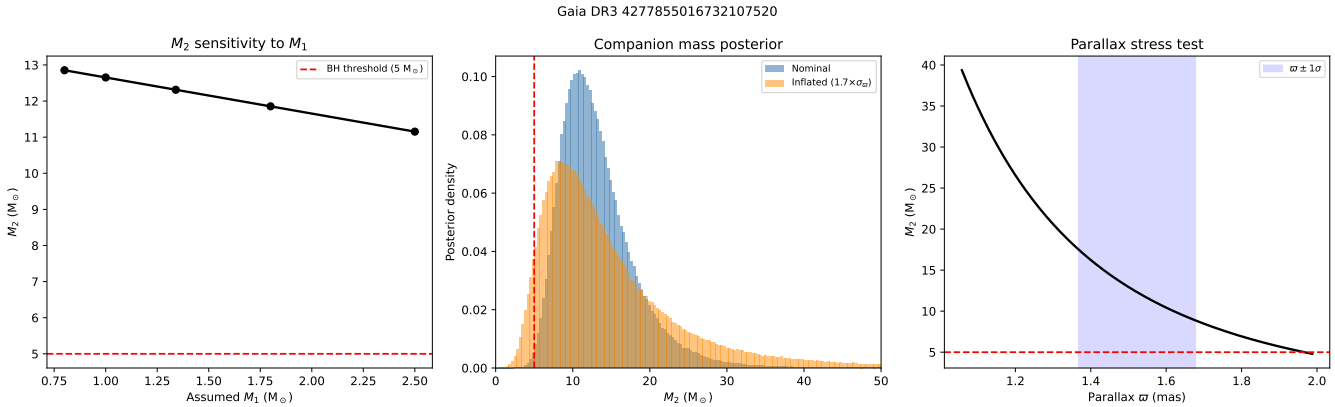

Figure 2. Companion mass posterior from Monte Carlo sampling. *Left:* Sensitivity to primary mass M_1 (all at nominal parallax uncertainty). *Centre:* Posterior with nominal (blue) and inflated ($\times 1.7$; orange) parallax uncertainty. Vertical dashed lines mark the $5\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$ and $10\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$ thresholds. The wide credible intervals reflect the $M_{\rm tot} \propto \varpi^{-3}$ scaling. *Right:* Companion mass as a function of parallax, illustrating the steep ϖ^{-3} dependence. These posteriors propagate published parameter uncertainties only; they do not account for potential systematic errors in the `Orbital` model itself.

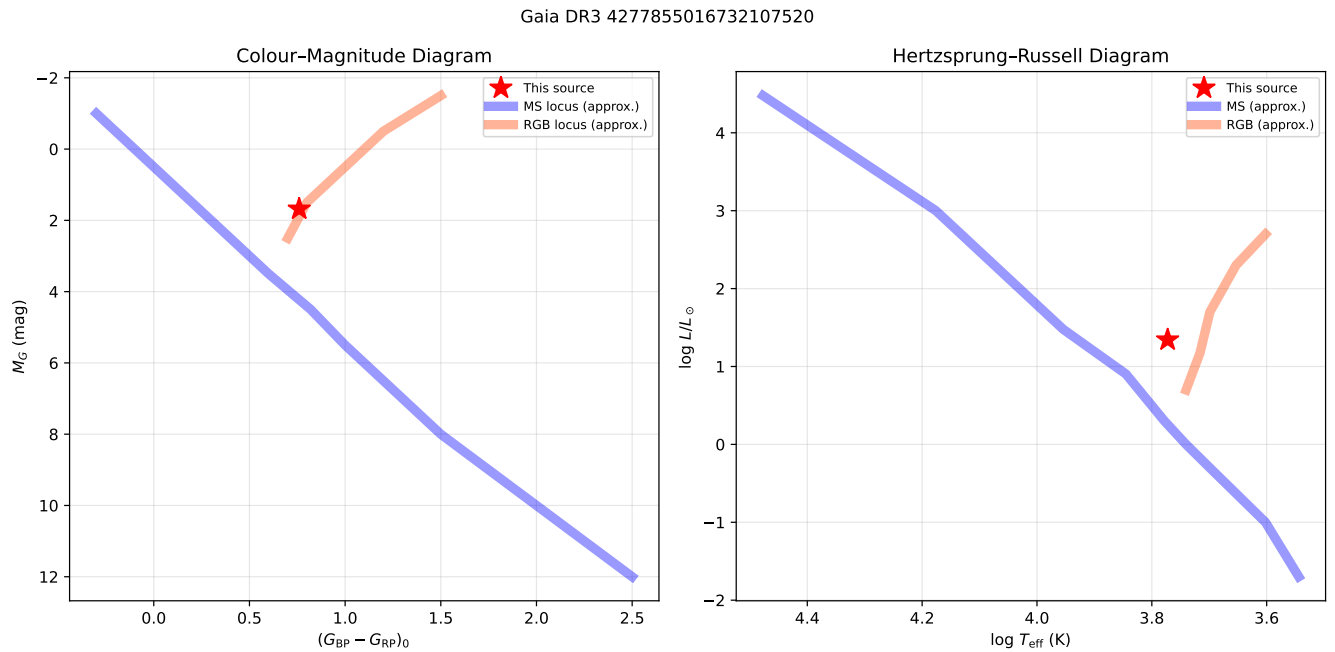

Figure 3. Placement of the primary star in the colour–magnitude diagram (*left*) and Hertzsprung–Russell diagram (*right*). The dereddened photometry places the star on the red giant branch, consistent with the GSP-Phot parameters. These loci are approximate; formal isochrone fitting is deferred to future work with independent spectroscopy.

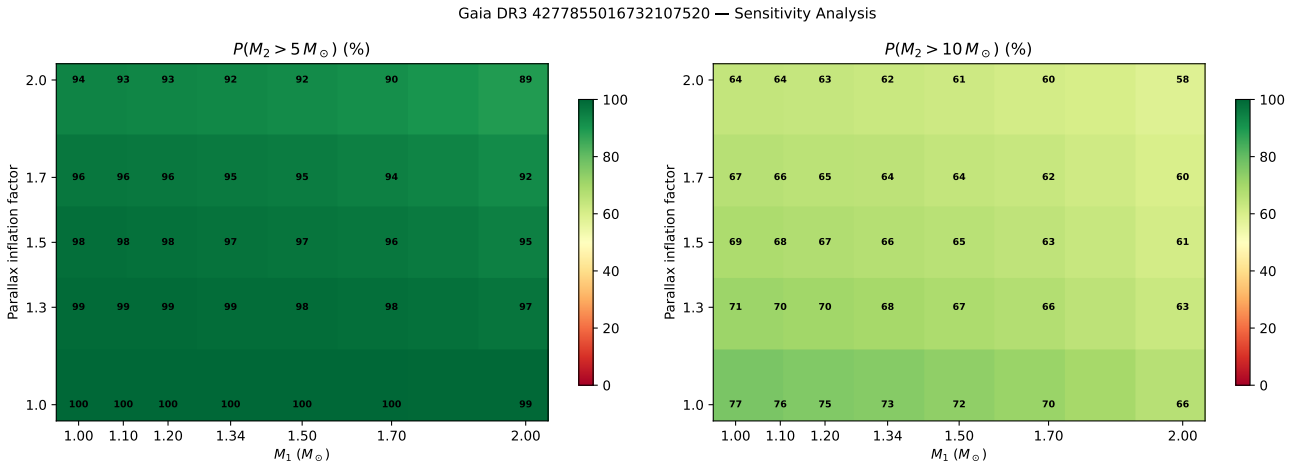

Figure 4. Sensitivity analysis showing $P(M_2 > 5\,\mathrm{M}_\odot)$ (*left*) and $P(M_2 > 10\,\mathrm{M}_\odot)$ (*right*) as a function of adopted primary mass M_1 and parallax-error inflation factor. At the fiducial values ($M_1 = 1.34\,\mathrm{M}_\odot$, inflation = 1.7), $P(M_2 > 5\,\mathrm{M}_\odot) \approx 95$ per cent.